

The Cartographer's Daughter

Her father had mapped the world. He had never mapped himself.

CEFR Level B1

Book 5 of 9

Adult Graded Reader

Setting: London and the Scottish Highlands. Present day, with the past arriving through her father's maps.

Genre: Family Drama / Discovery

Characters

- Seren — 37. Graphic designer. Her father died six months ago. She is going through his things.
- David — her father. Present through his maps and letters.
- Elena — 68. An academic geographer who knew David in his early career.
- Tom — Seren's partner. Present but secondary.

Her father's studio was exactly as he had left it.

This was Seren's doing, not neglect — she had asked her mother not to disturb it, and her mother, who had not shared the studio and had regarded it with something between affection and mild exasperation for thirty years, had complied.

The studio occupied the top floor of the house. It had north-facing windows, which David had required for the quality of the light, and it smelled of cartographic paper and ink and, faintly, of the pipe tobacco he had given up fifteen years ago but which had soaked permanently into the walls.

Seren stood in the doorway and looked at it for the first time since his death.

David had been a cartographer for the Ordnance Survey for twenty years and a freelance mapmaker for fifteen years after that.

The studio contained his professional work — surveys, revisions, the slow accretion of a career in precise representation.

But along the north wall, in the flat files that she had dusted without opening, were his personal maps.

He had told her about them, vaguely, over the years — maps he had made not for clients but for himself.

She pulled out the first drawer.

The map inside showed an island she did not recognise.

It had been drawn by hand, in pencil and watercolour, with the kind of detail that suggested years of observation rather than a single survey.

It showed a small island — roughly oval, with a rocky eastern shore and a more sheltered western bay. There was a settlement marked: eight or nine buildings, a jetty, a church.

The lettering was her father's hand — careful, italic, the same lettering she had seen on a hundred professional maps. But there was no scale bar, no north arrow, no grid reference.

These were the things a map needed to be useful. Her father had not included them.

She turned the map over. On the back, in pencil: GH — Summer 1978.

She was thirty-seven. In 1978, her father had been twenty-six.

Some were of recognisable places — sections of the Scottish Highlands, a stretch of Orkney coastline, what appeared to be part of the Welsh border. These were clearly survey work, or practice.

But eleven of the maps were of the same island, or appeared to be. The same oval outline, the same eastern shore. Different seasons — she could tell from the vegetation notes, the weather annotations.

The most recent was dated GH — Autumn 1992.

She had been born in 1987. She would have been five.

Seren had known, as a child, that her father had colleagues — academics, other geographers, the occasional mapmaker.

She found, in his address book, an entry for Elena Marsh, with a university address in Edinburgh.

She searched online. Elena Marsh was an emeritus professor of historical geography at Edinburgh — retired, but still publishing.

There was an email address.

Seren wrote a careful email, explaining who she was and what she had found.

Elena replied within three hours.

Her email said: 'I have been hoping that someone would find those maps. I was beginning to think they might have been destroyed.'

GH stood for Garvie Head — a small island off the west coast of Scotland, accessible only by a twice-weekly ferry from the mainland.

David had first visited in the summer of 1978 as part of a field survey. He had returned eleven times over the following fourteen years.

'He told me he had never mapped anything so completely,' Elena said. 'Most cartography captures a place at a moment. Garvie Head became something different for him. He kept going back. He wanted to understand how it changed.'

'Why did he stop?' Seren asked.

Elena was quiet for a moment. 'That is the more complicated question,' she said.

Elena had worked with David for three years, in the late 1980s.

She had visited Garvie Head with him once — in 1989, the summer Seren was two.

'There was a community there,' Elena said. 'Small — about forty people. They had been there for two generations. Fishing, some farming. Very self-sufficient.'

'What happened?' 'The ferry service was reduced in 1990 — economic decision, made in an office somewhere that had never seen the island. Without regular transport, the community couldn't sustain itself. By 1993, almost everyone had left.'

'And Dad?' 'He went back in 1992 to map the changes. He said afterwards that it had been a mistake. That he should have gone while there were still people there. That it was easier to map an absence than to have prevented it.'

reduced azaltıldı absence yokluk "Easier to map an absence than to have prevented it." His guilt is in those words.

Seren had known her father as a quiet, precise man who loved maps as objects — their capacity to hold, in compressed form, everything that had happened in a place.

The Cartographer's Daughter



Seren opens her father's archive and finds maps that hide a private history.

She had not known he had been involved in advocacy.

Elena told her: David had written to the ferry company, to the local council, to two MPs. He had produced a detailed analysis showing that the service reduction would lead to community collapse within three years.

'He was right,' Elena said. 'About the timeline. Almost to the month.'

'What happened with the letters?' 'Nothing. They were polite. They thanked him for his analysis. They made the cut anyway.'

Seren looked at the map on the table. 'He never told me any of this.'

'No,' Elena said. 'I don't think he talked about what he had failed to prevent.'

analysis analiz community collapse topluluk çöküşü polite kibarca failed to prevent önleyemediği "He never talked about what he had failed to prevent." That is the map of his silence.

Tom, who was used to Seren making decisions and then explaining them, said: 'When?' 'Next month. Before the weather changes.' 'Do you want me to come?' 'No. I need to go on my own.'

She was not sure why she needed to go on her own. She had thought about it and could not articulate a good reason, which suggested it was probably the right reason. She contacted the ferry company. The twice-weekly service had been reinstated in 2010, she was told, when the island had acquired a small number of new residents — incomers, mostly, attracted by the remoteness.

There were now eighteen people living on Garvie Head. Seren stood on the deck with one of her father's maps in her hand.

She had copied it — the 1989 map, which Elena had said was the most complete. She was comparing it with what she could see from the water.

The eastern shore was exactly as he had drawn it. The rocks, the particular way they stepped down to the water. She felt something she had not expected: recognition. Not of the place, which she had never visited, but of her father's eye. He had been here and had looked at exactly this and drawn exactly this.

The island seemed, for a moment, to be his shape.

The eighteen residents lived in two clusters — some in the original village settlement, which her father had mapped, and some in newer buildings near the southern shore.

She walked the island in an afternoon. She had the map in her hand the whole time, comparing it with what she saw.

Most of what he had drawn was still there. The church — roofless now, but standing. The jetty — extended, with a new floating pontoon. The outline of the older buildings. She found, in the original settlement, a woman who had lived there for twelve years and had heard of David Caldwell.

'The cartographer,' the woman said. 'Yes. Some of the older families remember him.'

older families eski aileler The older families remember him. He left a trace here — not just on paper.

The woman — her name was Aoife — had not been there during the original community. She had come twenty years after the collapse.

'But I've talked to people who were,' she said. They were sitting in Aoife's kitchen, which was warm and smelled of bread.

'What do they say about that time?' 'Mostly they talk about the ferry. About how quickly it happened. One month the ferry was twice a week. The next month it was once a week. Then once a fortnight. Then nothing.'

'My father wrote letters. Tried to stop it.' 'I know,' Aoife said. 'There are letters in the archive at the community hall. He was very thorough.'

The Cartographer's Daughter



With Elena, she begins to read geography and memory together.

Seren looked at her coffee. 'He never talked about it,' she said.

'Maybe,' Aoife said, 'it was too painful.'

painful acı verici His letters are in the community archive. He was thorough. And it was too painful to talk about.

The community hall had a small archive room — properly kept, she was surprised to find, with labelled folders and a finding aid.

Her father's letters were in a folder dated 1990–1991.

There were seven of them. She read all of them.

They were precise and passionate — not in an emotional way, but in the way of someone who had looked at a situation from every angle and was presenting the evidence as clearly as possible because they believed the evidence should be sufficient.

She thought: he believed in the right argument. He thought if you made it clearly enough, it would be heard.

She thought: I do that too.

She stayed on Garvie Head for two nights, in a room above Aoife's kitchen.

On the first evening, she sat outside and looked at the sea until the light went. The sea was dark and very present.

She thought about her father. She thought about the maps and the letters and the ferry and the forty people who had left.

She thought about what it must have been like to be the person who had documented a place in such detail and had then watched it empty.

She thought: he carried this for thirty years and never said anything. And I knew him for thirty-seven years and never asked the right question.

She was not angry. She was — she found the right word eventually — bereft.

never asked the right question doğru soruyu hiç sormamak "I never asked the right question." She is not angry. She is bereft.

On the second evening, she took it to the settlement and compared it with what she saw.

The houses were mostly roofless or gone. The church still stood. The jetty was the same jetty, though it had been repaired.

She found the spot where he must have sat to draw the settlement — a flat rock on the hill above it, with the right angle of view.

She sat there for a long time.

She did not draw anything. She did not take photographs.

She just looked at the thing he had looked at, from the place where he had looked at it.

It was enough.

A photograph of the view from the flat rock — not to reproduce in a map, just to have.

A copy of the community archive's finding aid, which listed his seven letters.

And something less tangible: a clearer picture of who her father had been.

Tom met her at the station. He could tell, he said, that something had happened, though he wasn't sure what.

'I found him,' she said. 'Not in the sense of — I mean I found a version of him I hadn't known existed.'

Tom was quiet. 'Is that good?' 'Yes,' she said. 'I think it's necessary.'

'How was it?' Elena asked.

'Smaller than I expected,' Seren said. 'And very clear. The air is different there. You can see things at a distance that you couldn't see in a city.'

'That's why David loved it,' Elena said. 'He said it was one of the few places where he felt like he could see properly.'

Seren thought about this. 'I found him,' she said, 'in the archive. The letters. He was so certain that the right argument would be sufficient.'

The Cartographer's Daughter



In the Highlands, the landscape gives shape to what had been
unsaid.

'Yes,' Elena said. 'He was always like that. He never quite accepted that the right argument could be ignored.'

'I'm the same,' Seren said.

'I know,' Elena said. 'I could tell from your first email.'

sufficient yeterli "I could tell from your first email." Elena saw it immediately. Like father, like daughter.

She spent October cataloguing her father's maps properly. Not for herself — for the archive. She had contacted the Scottish National Library, which had expressed interest in the Garvie Head series as a documentary record of a community before its dispersal.

She had also contacted the community archive on the island. They wanted copies.

She scanned all forty-seven maps. She wrote descriptions for each one — dates, techniques, the evolution of her father's approach to the island.

She found herself doing this with a degree of attention she had not given to anything since university.

'You're making a map of the maps,' Tom said one evening.

'Yes,' she said. 'I suppose I am.'

scanned taradı "A map of the maps." She is completing her father's work in her own way.

She had not made a hand-drawn map since a school project at fourteen. She was a graphic designer — she worked in digital, with precise tools and clean vectors.

This was different.

She drew Garvie Head from the photograph and from memory — the flat rock, the settlement, the jetty, the eastern shore.

She included her father's 1978 reference points and marked where things had changed by 1992 and again by her visit.

On the back, she wrote: GH — Autumn 2024. And then, below it: For D.C. Who saw clearly.

She framed it. She put it in the studio, on the wall above his desk.

The studio had north-facing windows for the quality of the light.

She understood this now in a way she had not when she was a child.

North light was consistent — it didn't change with the time of day, it didn't cast direct shadows, it didn't flatter or distort. It was the light for seeing things as they were.

She had been in the studio a dozen times since his death. She had begun to think of it as a kind of ongoing conversation.

He had mapped places and things and people's care for them.

She had found the maps, and the letters, and the island.

She thought: we both needed north light. He had it. I was still finding mine.

She sat at his desk. She opened her notebook. She began to draw.

flatter süslemek, güzelleştirmek distort çarpıtmak ongoing conversation devam eden sohbet a dozen times bir düzine kez "He had north light. I was still finding mine." She sits at his desk. She begins.

Story Vocabulary

The words below are collected from the story so the reading pages remain in a natural storybook format.

1. cartographic paper	kartografik kağıt
2. north-facing windows	kuzeye bakan pencereler
3. exasperation	sabırsızlık, bıkkınlık
4. complied	uydu
5. soaked into	sinmiş
6. neglect	ihmal
7. accretion	birikim
8. Ordnance Survey	İngiliz Devlet Harita Servisi
9. flat files	düz dosyalar
10. freelance	serbest çalışan
11. watercolour	suluboya
12. representation	temsil, gösterim
13. oval	oval
14. sheltered bay	korunaklı koy
15. jetty	iskele
16. scale bar	ölçek çubuğu
17. grid reference	koordinat referansı
18. italic	italik
19. recognisable	tanınabilir
20. Orkney	Orkney adaları
21. vegetation notes	bitki örtüsü notları
22. annotations	açıklamalar
23. survey work	haritacılık çalışması
24. stretch	kesit, bölüm
25. emeritus professor	emekli öğretim üyesi
26. historical geography	tarihsel coğrafya
27. entry	kayıt
28. colleagues	meslektaşlar
29. hoping that	... umuyordum
30. destroyed	yok edilmiş
31. accessible	ulaşılabilir
32. ferry	feribot
33. mainland	anakarası
34. field survey	arazi araştırması
35. captures	yakalar, kaydeder
36. complicated	karmaşık
37. self-sufficient	kendi kendine yeten
38. sustain itself	kendini sürdürmek

39. community	topluluk
40. generation	nesil
41. advocacy	savunuculuk
42. compressed form	sıkıştırılmış biçim
43. articulate	ifade etmek
44. remoteness	uzaklık, ücra oluşu
45. incomers	yerleşmek üzere gelenler
46. reinstated	yeniden başlatıldı
47. acquired	kazanmış
48. suggest	ima etmek, göstermek
49. deck	güverte
50. comparing	karşılaştırıyordu
51. stepped down to	... a doğru alçalıyordu
52. recognition	tanıma hissi
53. drawn exactly this	tam bunu çizmişti
54. his shape	onun şekli
55. clusters	kümeler
56. roofless	çatısız
57. pontoon	şamandıra
58. extended	uzatılmış
59. settlement	yerleşim yeri
60. collapse	çöküş
61. fortnight	iki hafta
62. thorough	titiz, kapsamlı
63. archive	arşiv
64. community hall	toplum merkezi
65. finding aid	katalog, bulma yardımcısı
66. passionate	tutkulu
67. sufficient	yeterli
68. evidence	kanıt
69. from every angle	her açıdan
70. labelled folders	etiketli klasörler
71. documented	belgeledi
72. empty	boşalttı
73. bereft	derin kayıp hissi
74. watched it empty	boşılırken izlemek
75. carry for thirty years	otuz yıl taşımak
76. angle of view	bakış açısı

77. repaired	tamir edilmiş
78. flat rock	düz kaya
79. must have sat	oturmuş olmalı
80. enough	yeterli
81. tangible	elle tutulur, somut
82. reproduce	yeniden üretmek
83. necessary	gerekli
84. version of him	onun bir versiyonu
85. less tangible	daha az somut
86. finding aid	katalog
87. certain that	... dan emin
88. at a distance	uzaktan
89. ignored	görmezden gelinmek
90. accepted that	... kabul etmek
91. could tell from	... den anlayabiliyordum
92. cataloguing	kataloglama
93. dispersal	dağılma, yerinden edilme
94. documentary record	belgesel kayıt
95. evolution	gelişim, evrim
96. degree of attention	dikkat derecesi
97. vectors	vektörler
98. reference points	referans noktaları
99. framed it	çerçeveledi
100. hand-drawn	elle çizilmiş
101. marked where	... in nerede olduğunu işaretledi
102. saw clearly	açıkça gördü
103. consistent	tutarlı
104. cast shadows	gölge düşürmek

After-Reading Activities

1. Vocabulary Practice — Match the Words

Match each word or phrase with the correct meaning.

Word / phrase

Meaning

1. cartographic

A. haritacılık ile ilgili

2. accretion

B. savunuculuk

3. advocacy

C. birikim

4. dispersal

D. dağılma

5. documentary record

E. belgesel kayıt

6. consistent

F. tutarlı

7. sufficient

G. yeterli

8. bereft

H. derin kayıp hissi

2. Fill in the Blanks

Choose the correct word or phrase from the box.

maps — letters — failed — north — silence — version

1. David's studio had _____-facing windows for the quality of the light.

2. Seren found eleven _____ of the same island in her father's flat files.

3. Her father had written _____ trying to save the ferry service on Garvie Head.

4. Elena said David didn't talk about what he had _____ to prevent.

5. Seren found a _____ of her father she hadn't known existed.

6. She realised that the map of his _____ was made of things he had failed to stop.

3. Comprehension Questions

True or False? Write T or F.

1. David's personal maps were kept with his professional archive files. ____

2. GH stands for Great Highland. ____

3. Elena had never visited Garvie Head. ____

4. The ferry service to Garvie Head was eventually reinstated. ____

5. David's letters to the ferry company successfully prevented the cuts. ____

6. Seren makes her own map of Garvie Head at the end. ____

Short Answer Questions

7. What is unusual about David's personal maps compared to his professional maps?

8. Why did David stop visiting Garvie Head in 1992?

9. What did David do to try to prevent the ferry service being reduced?

10. What does Seren mean when she thinks 'I do that too'?

11. What does Seren feel at the island on the second evening?

12. What does Elena say she could tell from Seren's first email?

13. What happens to the forty-seven maps after Seren returns from Garvie Head?

14. What does 'north light' represent in the final section?

15. What does Seren mean when she says she was 'still finding her north light'?

Answer Key

(Alıştırmaları yaptıktan sonra bakınız.)

Match: 1-A 2-C 3-B 4-D 5-E 6-F 7-G 8-H

Fill in the Blanks: 1. north 2. maps 3. letters 4. failed 5. version 6. silence

True / False: 1. F 2. F 3. F 4. T 5. F 6. T

7. The personal maps have no scale bar, north arrow, or grid reference — they are not made to be useful to others, only to record his own understanding of a place.

8. The community had nearly all left by then — he went back in 1992 to map the changes, but said afterwards it had been a mistake to go after the people had left.

9. He wrote seven letters to the ferry company, the local council, and two MPs, with a detailed analysis showing the service reduction would cause community collapse.

10. She has found her father's letters and recognised his belief that the right, clearly-made argument should be sufficient — and realises she operates the same way.

11. She feels bereft — not angry, but deeply aware that she never asked the right questions and that he carried this loss for thirty years without speaking about it.

12. That Seren had the same quality as her father — the same belief in clear evidence being sufficient.

13. She catalogues them, contacts the Scottish National Library and the community archive on Garvie Head, and scans and describes all forty-seven.

14. North light is consistent — it doesn't flatter or distort, it shows things as they are. It represents clarity of vision and honest seeing.

15. She means she is still developing her own way of seeing clearly — her father had found his, through cartography and Garvie Head; she is still finding her equivalent.